before (you loved me)

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Explicit

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

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Summary

Privacy between the two of them was never a concept anyway, but when Catra's first heat hits junior year of college, she doesn't want to let Adora out of her sight. Adora is safety and comfort to Catra, but having her around makes dealing with the new-found effects of her heat a bit more difficult.
(Catradora college roommates AU - prequel fic to 'on the other side')

Notes

This is a prequel fic to 'on the other side', and I'm not sure how much sense it will make when read stand alone/first.
The first and third chapter are Catra's perspective, the second Adora's.

Catra

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra can't believe she is here. She fucking *hates* it here.

But she is here, in the student health center, huddling in the hoodie she stole from Adora as she waits to be called. A walk-in appointment, so it could be awhile, leaving her to stew in the scent of chemical cleaners even *longer*. Fuck is she glad that Adora choose physical therapy as her route after she realized how many scents nurses bring home. She never would have been cut out for nursing, anyway. Too caring. She wouldn't have been able to handle seeing patients in pain.

Not that Catra is *in pain*, per se. At least not anything but emotional pain - about half of which is caused by the scents of the clinic. She eventually gets called, relieved to be ushered to the back and have her vitals taken. She listens to her human nurse draw in a sharp breath as she takes her pulse.

"Is your pulse normally this high?" she asks, politely, even though Catra can see her mentally making a note to google magicat vital benchmarks the moment she leaves the room. The perks of being a rare hybrid, even if their university is pretty well incorporated.

"No fucking clue, but probably not," Catra returns, grouchy, but *sue her*, she feels like shit and her fur is standing on end. The nurse just nods, marking it on her chart.

"Alright, what brings you into the clinic today?" she asks when she finishes filling out the form. Catra sulks in her hoodie. Adora's hoodie. Whatever. If Adora wants it back she can *fight* her for it. Catra will win. She has claws and she fights *dirty*.

"I need to know if I'm getting sick," Catra mutters, glaring down at where she is making a serious effort not to flex her toe claws into the tile floor. She was really hoping for a hybrid nurse – preferably a canidae or a feline so they can *understand* why she is worried.

"Your vitals are certainly elevated. What symptoms are you experiencing?" the woman asks as she shifts her tablet so Catra can't see what she is doing on it. *Definitely* pulling up medical references on magicats. This is why having grad students be the nurses is a bad idea, but Catra is not feeling up to walking to the clinic a few blocks over like she normally does. Normally Adora goes with her, but if this is what she thinks it is, she doesn't want Adora here for this.

"Dehydration. Cottoniness. Everything feels warm. Everything sounds too loud and scents are overwhelming. It is difficult to concentrate. It has been building for two days," Catra lists off, staring down at her feet still. After a moment of tapping on the screen, the nurse pauses.

"Have you had your first heat yet? Young adulthood is when they usually begin for magicats," she suggests gently. Catra sighs, ignoring the thud of her tail on the side of her chair. Yeah, she *knows*. Nineteen to twenty-two is the average start time. Guess who turned twenty-one recently.

"No, I haven't. That's why I'm here. To make sure it isn't anything *else* that is the problem," she admits, reluctantly. The nurse asks her several more questions – some *far* too personal for Catra's liking, she would like to keep her lust to *herself*, thanks – before the nurse tells her the doctor will be with her soon, but it is pretty clear Catra's diagnosis has already been decided.

She comes away from the appointment with a small care package containing information booklets and a feeling of dread.

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She goes straight back to their dorm and collapses face first in her bed – well, her half of the bed, anyway . They shoved the beds together as soon as they moved in, and though they get raised eyebrows from their RA every time there is a dorm check, no one has ever said anything. They will have to rearrange the room again at the end of the year, but they have been doing it since freshmen year and if Catra had to sleep more than a few feet from Adora she does not know she would actually *sleep*. Half the time she ends up on top of her anyway.

She is kind of regretting the decision now, though. She rolls over onto Adora's side of the bed, nuzzling into the sheets and breathing deep. She is nervous, but she isn't scared of this anymore. Even freshmen year of college, she still had Shadow's bullshit kicking around in her head-

"*Don't you already have enough scars from her, Adora? As soon as her first heat hits, she will maul you. She won't be able to control herself. It is best if you part ways now.*"

-but she knows better than that now. She started hooking up with the first friend she made outside of Adora just so she would know *something* about sex once her heats started and feel more in control of it. She couldn't risk fucking this up with Adora, and she nearly fucked it up with Scorpia in the process, but they are *good* now and they both got experience. Catra already knew by then that a lot of what Shadow said was *bullshit*, but she was still scared. She hoped having had sex before would help her control herself when the time came.

It was unnecessary, it turned out. At least, *hopefully*. Near the end of their first semester, their orientation class covered this, since a lot of hybrids start hitting their heats in college. Adora also did her own research when this came up in one of her biology classes, and she

relayed the things she found out to Catra, since neither of them really knew much about it before then.

Catra knows that really, she will just have her senses go into hyperdrive, along with her libido. She won't lose control, or be driven by lust, or tear Adora to shreds. That was all racist bullshit. Right now she feels anxious, a little horny, and that is about it. She kneads into the mattress, trying to calm herself. Adora will be back from football practice soon. Catra needs to figure out what she is going to do before then.

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Adora walks in, greeting her cheerily despite being visibly exhausted, and immediately says she is going to take a shower. As she enters the room, her scent fills the air, and Catra feels herself flushing. She manages to grunt out an affirmative, not turning over in their bed. She feels *warm*.

Adora hums as she strips out of her dirty practice clothes, shuffling into their shared bathroom. Luckily the two canidae next door they share the jack-and-jill with are neat, even if they are a bit loud and rude at times. Catra listens to Adora letting out soft sighs and groans as the hot water hits her sore spots. Practice was rough then.

Catra squirms a little in Adora's sheets. She is definitely wet. Is she going to have to deal with this constantly during her heat? Is it just because Adora is around? She feels a little light-headed from the sustained flush she has had ever since Adora walked in, but aside from that and her alert senses making her feel stretched thin, she mostly feels okay.

Adora emerges from the bathroom, wrapped in a towel and dripping wet. Catra feels her blush rise higher and promptly turns around to

face the wall. Just giving Adora privacy. Fuck. Living with her oblivious best friend has always had its difficult moments, but this is going to be *rough*.

"How was your calculus class?" Adora asks, conversationally, because to her it is just any other Wednesday night. Catra sighs, tucking her face into the sheets as she listens to the sounds of Adora getting dressed.

"It sucked. Nothing new," she relays. The *reason* it sucked was certainly new, Catra feeling twitchy and on edge in the open lecture hall, surrounded by strangers and getting sent looks by a few of them as class let out, but the outcome was the same. Her heat started during class, probably. It would explain why she couldn't concentrate on *anything* but the wrong smells surrounding her and how the chalk scraping against the board made her want to *die*.

"I got a big ass bruise at practice. Wanna see? It's *green*," Adora tells her, sounding *excited* about her injury as she crawls up onto Catra's side of the bed. Catra can hear her grinning. Adora is always going to be a bit of a jock – or maybe just a twelve-year-old boy. Catra doesn't turn over, regardless.

"I went to the health center after calculus," Catra tells her. She feels Adora pause, and then she is shifting to sit up on the bed beside Catra, reaching out cautiously to stroke down her arm. Catra feels herself shiver, a gentle purr starting in her throat as Adora pets through her fur. That always feels good, but right now her nerve endings feel like they are standing on end at having Adora touch her.

"Are you alright?" Adora asks softly, concern radiating off her in waves. Catra doesn't want that – she just wants Adora to pet her. She rolls over, not meeting Adora's eye as she turns to face her. It puts them closer together, scant inches between them as she fixes her gaze determinedly on Adora's hip. She takes a deep breath, steadying herself, and checks in with how she feels as Adora's hand hovers in the air above her, unsure of if she should continue now Catra has rolled over.

Catra is turned on, and a bit anxious, but that is about it. Being in a perpetual state of arousal for a week doesn't sound *fun*, but it doesn't sound like something that would drive her to jump Adora either. She knows Adora doesn't think about her like that, and she has been working on coming to terms with it. Despite how Catra *wants* her, she knows not to make a move.

She swallows, nudging a bit closer until she is brushing up against Adora's side. Adora drops her hovering hand into Catra's mane, stroking through it gently. Catra's purr returns, and she gives in to nuzzling against Adora's side. It feels so good and *safe* here against Adora. She kind of just wants Adora to hold her, stroke her hair, and keep talking about her day.

Catra takes a deep breath. She knows Adora is fine this in an academic sense, but even Catra doesn't know what the reality of it is going to entail. She just hopes Adora doesn't want to *give her space* or something. All she wants right now is Adora against her.

"I was feeling shitty. They think I'm in heat. My senses were running in overdrive during calculus. I felt paranoid," Catra mutters into Adora's hip. She feels her tail thud anxiously against the mattress as Adora's hand stills.

"Okay. What do you need right now?" Adora asks her, softly. The words make Catra's chest clench. She huffs, wriggling herself a bit closer. Cautiously, Adora resumes petting through her hair. Catra doesn't *mean* to sigh in relief, but she definitely does. Adora makes a soft sound. "You want to be pet?" she questions. Catra nods into her hip. She wouldn't *ask* her for it – she was a little worried Adora wouldn't want to be near her for the next week *at all* – but now she has Adora's hands on her it is pretty much the only thing she wants.

"Okay. I know you're going to be either extra standoffish or affectionate, depending. I don't know what I can do to help, though. You're going to have to tell me what you need," Adora tells her, gently scratching behind Catra's ears. Catra's chest explodes with a purr at the same time her heart does. Adora wants to *take care of*

her. The thought makes Catra press closer without really thinking better of it. Adora lets out a soft breath above her.

"Do you want a hug, or would that be too much contact? I don't want to overwhelm you," Adora asks her. Catra doesn't feel like she can answer around the lump – and purr – in her throat, so she just crawls over Adora and pins her to the bed.

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Adora's alarm goes off and Catra flat-out hisses, causing Adora to jolt a little beneath her. Adora tries to pull away, and sure, it is *probably* to turn the alarm off, but Catra is feeling unreasonable – nothing new there – so she clings onto Adora's shoulders and snarls against her throat as she tries to pull away. Adora is undeterred. She has the core strength to sit up enough to shut the alarm off, flopping back against the bed with Catra still clinging to her.

"I have class," Adora mumbles out beneath her, because the idiot had to sign up for a nine-thirty kinesiology course. Catra snarls again. Adora makes a weak noise beneath her. Okay, Catra is still waking up, but she knows she should not be baring her fangs against Adora's throat. She huffs and licks along the side of Adora's neck in apology, purring softly as she breathes in her scent.

"Moody," Adora mumbles, her voice still sleepy and distant. Her hands are on Catra's back now, idly stroking as she yawns. Catra huffs, but she just nudges in a little closer. Okay, yes, *she is*, but she is an asshole on a good day anyway and Adora should be long-accustomed to this. She doesn't actually sound *bothered* by it at least. Adora's hands on her back squeeze gently.

"I have to go to class. I told you, I'll come right back after," Adora tells her, sounding more awake this time. Unfortunately, so is Catra, and

that means the rational part of her brain is back online. This is what they agreed to last night, Catra taking her heat leave to sweat it out in Adora's bed – because she *refuses* to leave it – and Adora staying in the dorm with her other than to get them food or to go to class or work. Catra growls to herself as she forces herself to pull away. Her body immediately feels cold for the loss of Adora against her. She narrows her eyes down at Adora as she pulls back.

Adora smiles brightly at her, her hands falling away from Catra's back to instead reach up and sweep her hair out of her face for her. Catra realizes she is purring and leaning into the touch without even thinking about it. She immediately huffs, flopping down on the bed beside Adora and turning her back on her. Behind her, Adora sits up in the bed and *hovers*.

"It's okay to want affection right now, you know. That's pretty typical across the board. You can *ask* for it even," Adora tells her, cautiously reaching out and petting down her arm. Catra feels herself shiver beneath the touch. Adora seems to take that as a signal, flopping down in the bed and cuddling up behind her, wrapping an arm around her waist and humming softly. Catra squeezes her thighs together. She got off while Adora was getting them dinner last night and that seemed to satisfy her body all evening, but after a night spent sleeping in Adora's arms she is warming up again. Her mouth feels dry.

"You have stuff to do," Catra mutters. More important stuff than *holding her*, even if she just wants to melt into Adora arms, purring and kneading against the mattress. She forces her fingers to merely twitch as Adora squeezes her tighter for a moment before letting go.

"I do, but I'll be back in an hour and a half, okay?" Adora promises her, running a hand down her arm before she finally leaves the bed. Catra immediately rolls over and nuzzles into the spot she left, soaking in the warmth. Adora watches her with fond eyes for a moment before she sets to getting ready.

Catra tracks Adora's movements around the room, idly kneading into the mattress and nuzzling her cheek in against Adora's pillow. Adora gets her backpack ready and changes into real clothes, putting up her ponytail and tugging on her varsity jacket before turning to Catra and throwing her a smile.

"I'll be back by eleven. Make sure to check that your leave request was approved," Adora tells her, crossing the room to give her one last pet, stroking along her hair, before she leaves.

Catra waves vaguely to Adora as she leaves their dorm. When the door clicks shut behind her, Catra *immediately* shoves her shorts around her thighs, touching herself to find she is already wet just from being *held*. Fuck, she is desperate for Adora. Normally she is silent when she does this, but she can't hold back a shaky moan as she sets her hand to work. She clasps a hand over her mouth as her first orgasm hits, leaving her shaking and relieved, but not yet *done*.

She manages two more before she collapses back onto the bed, shivering with aftershocks as she nuzzles into the sheets and breathes Adora in, a content purr rolling through her as her frayed nerves finally relax.

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Catra's heat leave was approved, and she is excused from classes for the next seven days. Adora comes right back to the dorm from her classes, and she laughs when Catra growls at the foreign scents on her and sets to marking her.

"It's like when I would play with my other friends when we were kids and you would get jealous," Adora jokes as Catra marks her. Catra manages to hold back her growl. Adora is *right*, but she doesn't know that even then Catra was in love with her and staking her

claim. The fact that Adora is making such an innocent comparison now really goes to show how much she truly doesn't think of Catra that way.

Catra still lays in Adora's sheets to touch herself every time Adora goes to class or work. Adora catches her when she comes back too quickly from getting them dinner , and after a lot of defensive snarling, she manages to get Catra to calm down enough to tell her she *knew* Catra wasn't leaving her side of the bed for anything but the bathroom.

"It's *our* bed. I never really distinguished it beyond us having general sides. I don't care," she says with a shrug, expression open and innocent. The implication is there, even if neither of them directly address Catra's frantic movement to pull her shorts back up when Adora entered the room. Adora tousles her ears while Catra stares at her in shock. Catra *kind* of thinks of it the same way, but there is also a definite distinction between the scent on her side and Adora's.

Catra feels unsettled whenever Adora is gone, and generally horny *always*, but especially when Adora is home. Aside from that, some dehydration headaches and issues concentrating on her homework and online paralegal program, it isn't too bad for the first few days. When she tries to actually leave with Adora to go to the cafeteria she only makes it as far as their dorm's lobby before her fur is prickling too much and she turns back around, Adora hurrying after her and asking if she is okay, but as long as they stick to their system it *works*.

Catra had been worried about how this would go, but it turns out the answer is *fine* – at least until Saturday night.

Catra is brushing her teeth in their bathroom. She feels a bit awkward in it. The two canidae next door both had their heats earlier in the semester. Catra doesn't know them that well, so she has no idea if it was either of their first, but she *did* smell it on them in the shared space. She knows they can tell now what state she is in. She isn't *embarrassed* by it, it is normal and honestly not *that* different

from picking up on a human's period, but she still doesn't like projecting so much information about herself.

Only one of them is even home, although over her own hormones Catra can't tell which one it is through the wall. It turns out she doesn't need to. She didn't lock the neighbouring door to just brush her teeth, and there is a short rap on it before the door to the canidae's suite is opening and the lycan – of *course* it had to be her, she is the bitch of the two – outright *leers* at Catra.

Catra scowls to herself, spitting into the sink if only for the excuse to look away. She wasn't done yet, but she doesn't need to deal with heat jokes right now. Adora was obsessively tracing her thigh stripes – *colouring in the lines*, she calls it - before Catra made the excuse of brushing her teeth to escape, and she knows she can smell just how turned on she is right now.

"I don't know who left a gorgeous kitten like you hanging, but if you need help *taking care of it*, my roommate won't be back for another two hours," she tells her, grinning like a jackal from her spot in the doorway. Catra feels like a bucket of ice has been dumped over her, her fur bristling as her head whips around from the sink to glare at the other girl.

You shouldn't be making a pass at someone on their heat *anyway*, not unless they at least flirt first, but to use the word *kitten* is on a whole other level. She knows some feline hybrids like it, but it is still belittling, the kind of word humans throw around as a joke and don't realize how degrading and racially charged it is. Worse yet, a lycan would *know that*, having an equivalent term themselves.

Either she has no clue what kind of person she is, or she is relying on Catra being too worked up to say no, which she should know from her own heat is not how it *works*, but also tells Catra exactly what kind of person she is. The kind she would like to give a set of *scars*.

Before Catra can even snarl at her , she is startled by *her* bathroom door opening. Adora appears with the fury of a god, and before Catra's sluggish mind can really process what is happening, Adora has crossed the bathroom and grabbed De by the front of her shirt, shoving her back into her own dorm. De growls in shock as she stumbles backwards, nearly falling on her ass. Adora stands in the doorway, blocking entrance back into the bathroom. Her hands are curled into fists at her sides.

"You know that counts as harassment under university policy? Because *I* know you're the shittiest center fielder we've had in years and your coach is desperate to replace you. And he could in an *instant* if there was a report against you. Don't fucking speak to her like that again," Adora growls out, her arm muscles flexing bold from the effort of holding herself back.

De's ears pin back, and her tail tucks a little between her legs. Adora *sneers*, baring her blunt teeth at De. Fuck, she definitely picked that up from Catra, and Catra is fucking *soaking* now. The flood of heat between her legs is downright embarrassing, but luckily De is too busy being scared shitless to notice.

"You know what? I'm changing that threat to if you ever talk to Catra *at all*. I'll be watching you," Adora tells her , before leaning into De's dorm to grab the door handle and *slam* it. She doesn't even hesitate to lock De out of the bathroom. De has a key for the handle on her side, but the message is clear.

Catra swallows as Adora turns back to her. Adora still has her intense face on, the one Catra knows well from when they were in football together during high school and Catra was her running back. Catra's fur is standing on end a little as Adora wraps an arm around her back and gently ushers her back into their room. Adora locks the door to the bathroom from their side behind them, guaranteeing De keeps out.

Adora seems to realize Catra is in a bit of a *state*, because her intense expression softens a little and she gently herds Catra over to

their bed. Adora's hands are light as she lets them fall to Catra's thighs and she carefully picks her up to lift her onto Adora's side of the bed. Catra immediately turns to bury her face in the sheets, trying to calm her body and get some kind of control over herself again, honestly relieved for the help. A few years ago she would have turned it away, but after watching Adora go to the same lengths for her other friends, Catra now knows Adora is just trying to do right by her.

Adora is breathing a bit heavy from containing her fury. She crawls into the bed behind Catra, reaching for her and tugging her back against her chest without having to ask. Catra shivers a little as Adora pulls her into her arms and Adora freezes.

"What do you need right now, Catra? Unlike *her*, I don't want to presume," Adora tells her. She still sounds fucking pissed. The last time Catra heard her this mad they were fifteen and an asshole on their chemistry class was being racist to Catra. The resulting fight got all three of them sent to detention, but Adora walked away with a mere bruise while he walked away with stiches.

Catra walked away *definitely* wet, much like today. It isn't a violence thing, just an Adora thing, seeing her worked up and angry on Catra's behalf. Today it almost looked like jealousy, and though Catra knows it was just because of the racial implications in the proposition, that thought is enough to have a fresh wave of desire hitting her.

Catra whines softly and turns over in Adora's arms, nuzzling under her chin. Adora immediately wraps her arms tightly around her. It calms her, letting her breathe a bit easier with Adora surrounding her. She wasn't *worried* about Perfuma—Catra is far more of a scrapper than Adora is, and she could tear that girl to shreds if she needed to—but Adora's presence is still calming, especially considering how Catra's body is crying out for her.

"I've got you," Adora promises her, softly. Catra doesn't know if it is the adrenaline of the moment, or just that Adora wants to assure her,

but she drops a soft kiss against the base of Catra's ear. The gentle whine Catra gives and the way she nudges up into the touch is completely involuntary and *embarrassing*. Adora draws in a soft breath, and then she bends and repeats the affection against the other ear.

Catra isn't up to purring, not after that, but she trills lightly. Adora lets out a soft noise, reaching up to carefully stroke her hair—and also tamp it down out of her face, Catra suspects. Adora has been damn-near suffocated by her mane before.

"I know you could have handled that yourself. I *know* that. But you shouldn't have to put up with it at all," Adora assures her, because as much as Catra has learned this is just how Adora loves, Adora has also learned Catra used to find it condescending, even when she enjoyed seeing Adora throw all caution to the wind for her. Catra *does* purr now, low and weak as she nudges closer. Adora clutches her in turn.

Catra whimpers a little bit as the contact makes her thighs squeeze together. "Water," she manages against Adora's throat. Staying hydrated has been an *issue* the past few days. Adora lets out an affirmative grunt, slowly releasing her and laying Catra back on the bed so she can scramble up to fetch their filter pitcher from the minifridge. Catra finds her claws digging into the mattress as she watches Adora refill her half-empty glass and return the pitcher to the fridge.

Adora smiles softly at her as she approaches the bed again. She settles on the edge of the bed as Catra sits up, taking the glass from her and chugging it like a beer. She doesn't drink the whole thing, but she drinks *a lot* of it before handing the cup back to Adora. She flops back against the mattress as Adora deposits the cup on their fold-out tray table and then returns to hover near the edge of the bed.

"I swear, Adora, if you don't hold me for the rest of the night, I'm going to do something drastic," Catra tells her. Adora lets out a

shaking breath approaching a laugh, but she climbs into the bed beside Catra with a slowly spreading smile. She wraps Catra in a tight hug, cradling her in against her chest.

"I'm here," she promises. Catra clenches her thighs again, still hopelessly turned on, but what she needs more than getting off is for Adora to hold her. She can manage.

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Adora has work on Sunday morning. Catra pins her to the bed when she tries to leave, Adora laughing as Catra marks every inch of her damn neck. Adora seems just as reluctant to leave as Catra is for her to go, but Adora's paycheck is the only one they have right now, and she needs to take the shift. They agreed Adora would split her time between work and school so Catra could split hers between school and *more* school. It will be worth it when she graduates with both her degree and her paralegal diploma, able to support them both while Adora goes through *her* secondary education, but right now Catra just wants to wrap her legs around Adora' s waist.

She never calmed down, last night. The chaotic few moments pushed her from *turned on* to *worked up*, but she also couldnt make herself let go of Adora, much less ask her to leave so she could get off. Adora never offered after Catra told her to hold her, despite clearly being able to tell how worked up she was from all of Catra's shifting. She held Catra as close as she clung to Adora, apparently unbothered by having a *very* horny magicat in her arms as long as she could assure her.

Adora leaving *should* be a good thing. It should give Catra time to get off – time to get of f *several* times if that is necessary. Instead, Catra quietly asks Adora to hang back a minute before she heads out the door. Adora pauses, turning to her, and Catra doesnt make

eye contact as she slips from the bed and pads to the bathroom. Adora lets in a sharp breath as she does so.

Catra isn't worried, but she just doesn't want to *deal* with it. She feels better knowing Adora is right there, within range to overhear again if anything does happen. Catra only takes a few moments, and when she slips back out the bathroom door it is to find Adora leaning against the wall with her arms crossed. She had her bitchface on until the moment Catra emerged, and then she smiles at her, soft and *touched*. Catra feels herself blush as Adora crowds in close to reach around her and lock the bathroom door handle.

Adora hesitates, leaning over her, and Catra's blush only gets worse as she blinks up at her. She is pretty sure she looks *shy* as she does it, uncertain and hopeful. Adora still has that soft smile on her face. She leans down, pressing a gentle kiss against the base of Catra's ear. Catra feels herself melt a little bit beneath her.

She marks Adora two more times before she lets her get out the door. Adora accepts the nuzzles happily. Catra quickly makes her way to bury herself in their bed, yanking off her clothes as she does so. Adora won't be back for a few more hours, and Catra is pretty sure she is going to need to go a few rounds between now and then. She will pull some of Adora's clothing out of the hamper before she gets back, but until then, Catra *needs* to work out this desire.

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She touches herself for an hour – she doesn't get off. She just works herself up further, keyed up, annoyed, and anxious. She feels close and *not at all*. She keeps trying to calm herself, slowing down and nosing into the sheets, breathing deep, and it does help her relax a little but it doesn't *get her there*, no matter the fantasies she plays in her head. All of them center around Adora, anyway. She just *wants*

her, she always has. Since before Catra knew what a fantasy was, she was having them about Adora.

She gives up, tries to focus on her work, and she does do *some* of it, but she is still turned on. She pulls her rarely-used vibrator out from the box Adora *knows* it is hidden in but has never commented on. She finally manages to get off, but it doesnt relax her like she thought it would. She isnt so turned on, but she also doesnt untense.

She flops back down into their bed, growling to herself as she checks the clock and sees it will two more hours before Adora gets home.

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Catra jumps Adora when she gets home. Not *like that* – she has put clothes back on, even if they are Adora's clothes from Friday – but she grabs her the second she is through the front door and changed out of her uniform, dragging her to the bed and shoving her down onto it so she can climb atop her.

Catra buries her nose into Adora's pulse point and immediately begins purring. *This* is what she was looking for when she was desperately fucking herself all morning. Adora lets out probably her third surprised sound in the last few seconds, but Catra wasnt really paying attention. Despite her surprise, Adora dutifully wraps her arms around Catra without question.

Catra goes a bit *limp* in her arms, kneading into Adora's shoulders where she is still holding onto them.

"Are you doing okay?" Adora asks her, softly, as she cradles her close. Yeah, *no*.

"I couldn't get of f. I missed you. I don't feel safe," she murmurs, not really realizing how *related* those three statements are until she says them. Any other time, and she probably would not admit *any* of that, but she is feeling vulnerable right now. Adora lets out a breath and then pulls her in tighter. Catra feels a weak purr start in her chest and it is honestly a *relief*. She feels so much better in Adora's arms. She is turned on again – still, whatever – but having Adora around her helps the tension melt away. Tension she was attributing to her keyed-up state, but now she suspects was just from Adora leaving.

"I *am* talking to Be' s coach. It will be the final excuse he needs to put her removal into motion. "That- that was *not* respecting consent," Adora tells her. Catra didn't even know there *was* this drama with their softball team – enough of a drama that apparently Adora has heard about it over on the football team. She still purrs softly as she nudges into an indignant Adora's arms. Adora abandons her huff immediately, cradling Catra in close against her chest.

"What do you need right now?" she asks, softly . Catra swallows, knowing that Adora is no doubt referring to her shifting hips.

"Don't leave," she rushes out, and then immediately bites her lip. "I mean, I can ignore it. As long as it doesn't bother you," she tells her . If someone she wasn't into was practically twitching from the ef fort to not grind on her, she knows she would be uncomfortable, but Adora is also *Adora*, so Catra just might get away with this. Beneath her , Adora hesitates.

"Okay , I'm here. As long as you need," she promises her . Catra lets out a soft sigh, nuzzling into Adora' s neck. She is going to *need* for a while yet.

Chapter End Notes

> When I was moving into my freshmen dorm, my neighbours spent three minutes trying to explain to the RA that they'd known each other since middle school and were best friends when she discovered they had shoved their beds together

immediately. At the time they both had boyfriends. I wonder if that is still true.

Adora

Chapter Notes

The idiot is on parade.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora wasn't really sure what to expect from Catra's heat. She has felt like she is constantly on eggshells since it started, worried about doing anything that is too much. Catra is so *affectionate* right now, and physical affection can set her on edge normally. Adora knows she is the more touchy of the two of them and she is worried about getting too comfortable and touching Catra in a way she doesn't like. Adora knows it is possible to give consent during a heat, both to platonic touches and more, but she is still anxious about how to do right by her suddenly-clingy roommate. She is used to Catra sitting nearby, not *in her lap*, and she is not sure what to do with the change.

Despite her worry, how touchy Catra is with her right now is also a comfort. Her heat - especially her first - is a very vulnerable time, and she hisses at the mere thought of being around anyone but Adora. Adora doesn't have abandonment issues, she just- has *issues* that have to do with losing people in her life. Catra has been the one constant always there for her. Maybe that is why she reacted as violently as she did to Dave. Catra has deemed her safe and placed trust in her. Adora's subconscious wanted to follow through on that promise of safety, probably.

She doesn't know what to do now, though. Catra hasn't broken contact since Adora got back from work. They both did their homework tangled up in each other, and dinner time is approaching, but Catra seems no more inclined to let go of her now than when she first arrived. She is flushed and has been for a while, her pupils dilated and hips twitching occasionally. Adora doesn't mind - she

knows Catra is just dealing with some stuff right now - but she is worried about leaving her alone like this.

Yesterday, Adora would have easily left so Catra could have some alone time, but as dinner has approached Catra has become cagier, digging into Adora with her claws every time she shifts in a way that could so much as *hint* that she is pulling away. Catra has been staying in her bed because it makes her relax, but now she feels so unsettled in the room she doesn't even want to be in it alone.

Adora doesn't want to leave her alone, either. She is going to *do* something about Hordak - she is pretty sure the canidae is here on a softball scholarship her performance has *not* been living up to - but for the moment, she is just doing her best to relax Catra. She is furious at Hordak's utter disregard for consent, but making sure her friend is okay is her top priority right now. Catra has untensed since Adora got home - she is idly kneading into the bed and purring right now, actually, as she nuzzles into Adora's shoulder - but every time she glances at the clock some of that tension comes back and she clings to Adora tighter.

"The cafeteria closes in an hour," Adora is eventually forced to point out. Catra snarls into her collarbone. Adora isn't bothered by the reaction. She doesn't mind Catra snarling or baring her fangs *anyway*, but she pretty quickly figured out that Catra's vocalizations go up during her heat. Her purrs, trills, growls, and hisses have all climbed in number. Adora runs a hand down Catra's back and that seems to calm her *some*.

"I don't want you to go. I feel good right now. I'll get all worked up again if you go," Catra mumbles into her shoulder. Adora pauses, dropping one hand to Catra's hip to lightly squeeze. Catra huffs. "Worked up as in *anxious*. I've been turned on for four fucking days," Catra tells her. Adora snorts, running her hand back up to the more respectable location of Catra's shoulder.

Catra wriggles a bit against her, completely absently. Adora is pretty sure she doesn't know she is doing it, or if she does, that she doesn't

know how *often* she is doing it. Adora holds her a little closer, because she seems to like that, and Catra lets out a soft whimper approaching a moan. She stills, seeming unsure, so Adora just squeezes her tighter. Catra lets out a full moan at that and then *pants*, either from the effort of the sound or from the shock of it leaving her.

"I'm sorry," she manages, embarrassed and anxious, her face still tucked in against Adora like she is afraid of what she would see if she pulled back. Adora swallows. That noise kind of *hit* her. It is only natural, she tells herself. She is aware of how attractive Catra is, and any lesbian would be turned on by that sound anyway.

"It's okay. I know you're worked up right now," Adora tells her quietly. Catra lets out a soft noise of acknowledgement against her shoulder and licks weakly at the side of her neck. Adora is pretty sure it is a thank you for being chill about this. She knows she is an unusual amount of unbothered by it, but she has been preparing for it for a while now. Any of their other friends would have drawn the line long ago, probably around when Catra started getting off in her bed, but despite Adora *knowing* it is weird, it really doesn't bother her.

They grew up in the *same* bed after all, and Adora knows Catra used to get off in that. She doesn't know why it should suddenly bother her now when it didn't before. They practically sleep in the same bed now, even if they technically have sides made up of their individual mattresses. At the end of the day, Adora doesn't care if Catra is a few inches over to the left. Catra nuzzles against her, purring even as her hips twitch again. Adora bites her lip.

Adora *knows* she is attracted to Catra, her body's reactions to her friend back in high school made that clear. She ignores it, usually. They are friends, and she doesn't want to make Catra feel uncomfortable. It is just attraction, after all – it is normal and healthy, if a bit awkward at times, especially times like *now* when she has to feel Catra turned on against her. She isn't going to let Catra go – she clearly needs the comfort of the touch – but if they could reposition it would probably help.

"Catra?" Adora prompts softly, raising one hand to squeeze at the back of her neck. Catra flinches a little, but doesn't pull back. Adora continues on, undeterred. She knows Catra is probably worried about Adora reacting to the movement of her hips, given the snarling that had taken place when Adora had walked in on her getting off before. "Can you roll over for me?" she requests. After a moment, Catra complies silently, twisting in her arms until her back is pressing against Adora's chest. Adora wraps her arms around her waist and holds Catra close against her.

This is easier. Catra relaxes in her arms again, and Adora is no longer hyperaware of her friend's hips against her, even if Catra is still twitching occasionally. Catra seems more comfortable, too, no longer drawing in a sharp, worried breath every time she twitches. Now that her hips aren't pressing against Adora with the motion, she relaxes and merely releases soft sighs as her legs shift occasionally.

Adora glances at the clock. The cafeteria really is going to close soon, and it is too late at night for her to text one of their friends to run out and get them food from it. They can't afford to order takeout right now. If it weren't for their meal plans being included in their need-based scholarships, they would have starved on Adora's meager paycheck. If they are going to eat tonight, Adora needs to head to the cafeteria soon, but she also doesn't want to *leave* Catra like this.

Adora's anxiety at the very idea makes her pull Catra closer again, and Catra releases a moan as her hips twitch again. Adora swallows, trying to run through their options in her head. Adora needs to leave in the next thirty minutes if she is going to make it through the cafeteria lines in time to grab them dinner. She needs to figure out what she can do to make Catra comfortable with her leaving first, though.

Catra shifts in her arms again and then *curses*, under her breath and entirely to herself. Adora presses a little closer, hoping to ease her, and feels Catra's hand twitch down in response. Her entire body is beginning to tense with her desire, muscles tight as Adora cradles

her closer, and yet she *can't get off*, not with how tightly she is wound when she is alone. An idea is forming in the back of Adora's mind, and it is weird, even she can admit that, but-

But Catra turns her face to bury it in the pillow, not quite smothering her whimper into the bedding, and Adora just wants her to be okay again. She wants Catra to relax, and she wants her to be able to be alone without anxiety again. Adora is what is making her feel safe right now, and even if this makes things *awkward*, it will be worth it if it lets Catra be okay again. Right now, Adora is fairly certain Catra couldn't fall asleep even with Adora holding her.

"Catra, do you need to get off right now?" Adora asks, keeping her voice low. It feels wildly inappropriate to be asking so plainly, but it is step one. In her arms, Catra stills in the middle of shifting her legs. After a second, Catra untenses a little and releases a shaking breath, her shoulders falling.

"I can't. I feel better with you holding me. Please don't stop," Catra asks, her voice small and anxious. Adora swallows. Catra has been getting better at being vulnerable these last few years since they got out of Shadow's and it has been safe to, but she still is not usually this open about it. It solidifies in Adora's mind what she needs to do.

"I won't," she promises, shuffling a little closer to press all along Catra's back and tug her in tighter with the arm she has wrapped around her waist. In her arms, Catra shivers a little. Adora swallows. "If you *could* get off, do you think it would help you relax while I go get us dinner?" she asks, because if the answer is no then there is no point even suggesting this awkward thing. Catra's tail thuds heavily against the mattress, the tip *wapping* against Adora's shin, but she ignores the resulting sting. She has had far worse. Her bruise from Wednesday is still purple.

"Yeah," Catra breathes in her arms, emotion clear in her voice, but Adora can't quite tell what it is, not without any other clues to lead her there. If she could see Catra's face she could probably deduce if

it was just nerves or something else, but as it is she can't tell from her spot behind the bulk of her mane.

"You asked me to hold you, and I'll do that, but if you want to- do whatever you need during that, it's fine. I just hate seeing you anxious like this," Adora tells her. In her arms, Catra draws in a sharp breath, her tail thudding against the mattress once more. Adora waits, feeling her own heart beat a little fast against Catra's back. This is *already* awkward.

"I don't want you to think I'm trying to come onto you. If you want I could just stay somewhere in the room-" she starts to suggest instead, because she *really* needs Catra to know she isn't trying to pressure her or suggest she is going to *touch* her. Adora would never, not during her heat and not outside of it. Hot roommate aside, they are friends first, and she would never do something to jeopardize that.

She is cut off by Catra grabbing at her wrist, tugging her closer as if to stop her from leaving before she even *started*. Adora lets out a soft breath, tightening her grip on Catra a little to assure her. "I'm here. I just don't know how else to help you, Catra," she finally finishes, her voice as lost as she feels. Catra has hooked up a few times in the past, but this is still outside of *normal friend stuff*. She just hopes it isn't overstepping to offer. Catra used to hook up with Scorpia, and though that was a disaster, it didn't bother Catra at the time. In her arms, Catra lets out a slow breath.

"Like this?" she asks, her voice soft, so quiet Adora has to strain to understand it. It takes her a second to understand the words, and then another to actually process them. She pauses, evaluating their current position. She can't exactly think of a better one - at least not one that wouldn't feel more invasive to Catra's privacy - so she just nods into Catra's hair.

"Yeah? I can hold you and all I can see is your hair, so- like this, if it would help," she returns, flexing her arm around Catra's waist as if to demonstrate. Catra actually chuckles a little at that, her hips shifting,

but it is *true*. Catra's mane is kind of taking up Adora's entire field of vision right now. It is silent for a few moments as Catra shifts in her arms, an awkward silence where Adora regrets all her decisions that have led her up to this moment.

"Are you sure about this?" Catra asks, her voice still quiet. Adora feels herself relax a little, realizing Catra is actually considering it. She didn't overstep *too* badly. She nods, suddenly feeling confident in herself. Catra is okay with this. She thinks it will *help*.

"It'll be a bit awkward, but I don't mind, and I just want you to feel okay again," Adora tells her , cautiously stroking her hand splayed over Catra's abdomen and then *immediately* freezing. Petting Catra is not unusual, especially not as a way to soothe one or both of them, but in this *context* it feels like too much contact. Catra lets out a soft breath.

"Okay ," she agrees, her voice a little rough. She doesn't move so Adora just flexes her arm around Catra' s waist, pulling her a little closer to *show* her it is okay. Catra whimpers softly at being repositioned, but the movement prompts her to move her arm. Adora really can't see what she is doing, but she can feel the movement as Catra skims her hand down to slip inside her own waistband.

The soft breath Catra releases as she finally touches herself sends a jolt through Adora. Her nerve endings feel like they are straining, attentive to every movement and sound. She can feel Catra's muscles flexing with the movement of her hand against herself. She can feel the way Catra's breath stutters as twitches her hips into her touch. The noise sends a shiver through Adora, but she forces it down. Absolutely not. This is just something she is doing for her friend. She can be a lesbian later, on her own time, thinking about *anything* but the sound of Catra letting out soft breaths as she touches herself.

Catra is wet enough that even just touching her clit is creating slick noises with every movement. Or maybe she *is* doing more, and Adora just can't feel it. She doesn't know why that ef fects her the

way it does, but there is a burning heat in her gut she can only desperately try to extinguish. Adora has never so much as kissed someone, having no interest in interrupting the good dynamic she and Catra have going by bringing someone else into their life plans. That must be why her breath is catching. It is her first exposure to something like this, Catra jerking a little in her arms and Adora's grip on her instinctively flexing to hold her steady.

"*Adora*," Catra moans in response. The spike of heat between her legs makes her mouth dry, but even worse is the way the air leaves her lungs and her heart pounds at hearing Catra say her name like that. It is a reasonable response for Catra to give – Adora is *holding her down*, after all – but it makes Adora's entire body light up. She presses closer without even deciding to.

"This okay?" she manages to ask, her voice as soft as Catra's was earlier now just to hide her utter *state*. If Catra has noticed the heat building at her back, it hasn't caused her to slow her hand or the rocking of her hips. Catra whimpers, her voice *ragged* along with her breathing as she nods desperately and arches into her hand. She is pent up from the day of tension, *clearly*, because she whimpers Adora's name again, soft and *pleading*.

Fuck. *Fuck*, that hits somewhere deep in her ribs. Adora tugs Catra closer by the waist, doing her best to plaster against her back and surround her, hoping it will be *safe* and not *overwhelming*. She just wants to envelope Catra in her touch right now, to assure her as Catra leaves herself open in a way she rarely ever does.

"I'm right here. You're safe," she assures, hoping that is what Catra was calling out to her searching for. Catra lets out a soft cry, another moan of her name, almost *relieved*. It seems Adora has found what she needed. "It's okay. It's just us," she adds on, the words difficult to form with her throat this dry. Her heart is hammering like a jackhammer right now, threatening to break her ribs and leave her shattered. For some reason, she can feel adrenaline flooding into her system.

"Adora," is the weak whimper she gets in response. It has all the tones of a *thank you*. Adora feels trapped in her own chest, her breaths coming unevenly as she cradles Catra close.

"I've got you," she assures. Catra whimpers in response, and then her hips are jerking forward into her hand. She cries out *Adora* when she comes, an utterly desperate sound, and Adora's heart nearly falls out of her chest.

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Adora is laying on her back, staring up at the ceiling with a purring magicat in her arms, and *absolutely panicking*.

Her first thought when she heard Catra say her name like that was to say *I'm here, I love you*. She swallows reflexively just at the echoing of the words in her head. Catra seems far too boneless to notice the epiphany overtaking Adora and *ruining her life* right now. She collapsed back into the sheets, panting and breathless, and just barely managed to roll over into Adora's arms and mumble out a *thanks* before she promptly passed out.

Adora needs to *go*. The cafeteria closes in fifteen minutes. She doesn't really want to sneak out while Catra is asleep, but if she can manage to get back before she wakes then hopefully they can avoid her having any anxiety issues, which *was* what Adora thought the point of this whole thing was. She is swallowing a lot of realizations right now, not the least of which is the subconscious desire that was driving her choices tonight, her choices yesterday, fuck, her choices her *whole life*.

She and Catra have a life planned together. They planned it when they were fifteen and they were the only family either of them were ever going to have. They would always be there for each other ,

always have each other's back, because if they lost each other than they would be truly *alone*. No one else in the world cared about them. Adora had a dad lying in a hospital bed, true, but she couldn't *rely* on him. She couldn't even know if he would wake up again after the stroke.

Now, they may have other friends, Catra may even go with her to visit her dad a few times a year, but they are the closest thing to family either of them have. It has never been *sisterly* or anything like that – they both knew they were lesbians from a young age, after all – but it is still all they have, and Adora had to go fuck that up.

When did she do it? When did she fall in love and bury the emotion behind the shed where it belongs – where it *should still be*? Why did she have to make this offer and then hear Catra say her name like *that* just because she was in the throes of her heat and Adora was trying to comfort her.

Adora's hands shake a little as she gently slides Catra off her, making sure to gather Catra's phone and tuck it into where her hand is lying limply on the mattress so she can call Adora should she wake while she is gone and need assurance. Adora doesn't bother with a note – it will slow her down, and she already wasted enough time on her epiphany. She pulls on her tennis shoes, determining to process on her way to the cafeteria.

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Adora has made, at most, about one percent progress processing by the time she returns to their dorm. She unlocks their door as carefully and quietly as she can. She breathes a sigh of relief when she swings the door open and sees Catra still utterly limp in the sheets. She would have felt terrible if she woke up alone, but Catra also *needs* to eat.

It does not have to be right this minute though. Adora sets up her own to-go box on her desk as quietly as possible before tucking Catra's into the fridge. Catra is purring softly in her sleep, hands kneading into the bed, so she is clearly *out of it* and might be for awhile more. It gives Adora some time to figure out what the hell she is going to do as she quietly eats her food.

She got herself rice, a rare indulgence after acclimatizing herself to Catra's low-grain diet years ago, but it doesn't effect Catra in anyway if Adora has it, and she needed to give herself *something* tonight. She eats her rice slowly and watches Catra sleep. She looks utterly content, boneless and relaxed as her hands absently knead and her ears twitch occasionally. The entire room is filled with the gentle rumble of her purr. It is *peaceful*, except for Adora's inner turmoil.

She can't let this change anything. It has definitely been a thing for awhile now, and she has been dealing with it just fine not knowing about it. Catra is all she has, and she is all *Catra* has. She needs to make sure she stays normal about this, especially considering what they just did. Adora may not have realized *this* at the time, but she knew she was getting off on Catra getting off right away, at least up until the realization hit her like a bucket of ice, thoroughly stopping every other process in her body.

Catra lets out a soft *prbbt* in her sleep, nuzzling into the sheets, and Adora's chest does a painful clench she has felt for years but never thought twice about before. She turns back to her food, eating with purpose if only to distract herself. She can *handle this*. She can bury it, and make sure it doesn't ruin any of their plans together.

Right now, Adora is the one supporting them. What if Catra found out how she feels and was uncomfortable with it, but felt trapped with her because she was too busy with her dual school program to work herself? Adora never wants Catra to feel *controlled* like that again. Right now, they are happy, and they can *stay* that way as long as Catra never finds out. It doesn't have to change their behaviour – Catra clearly hasn't minded anything they do together so far.

They are best friends. They do a lot together, physically, emotionally, even financially. Hell, they have a *joint bank account* since Catra doesn't have a job and couldn't afford the fees of having her own. They lean on each other for support in every way. Adora *can't* let her stupid feelings get in the way of the one stable thing they have built together.

They have always been touchy, anyway. Adora is starting to realize *why*, that her urges to touch Catra aren't just related to her stimming, but Catra has never minded everything they are together. Adora doesn't *need* any more than what she has now. She doesn't need to be weird about this, or different. She is happy with what she has already, she tells herself. At least she has been happy up until this moment, unexplained urges and unknown yearning for *something* aside.

She just has to be normal when Catra wakes up. And not *too* normal. She has to be exactly how she was this morning, checking on her but not going *too far*. She has been holding herself back for a long time, she is starting to realize. She just needs to *maintain*.

Chapter End Notes

> Normally I update Tuesday/Saturday, but seeing as I have finals and projects due on those days, I think I'll be updating Wednesday/Sunday next week.

Catra

Chapter Notes

> I have a project due tonight I haven't started but in my defense I have a no-penalty late turn-in left. Have some gay idiots.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra wakes slowly, feeling groggy and a bit confused. She doesn't *remember* going to sleep, but Adora's hand is gentle in her hair, so she assumes things are fine. She blinks her eyes open, squinting at her friend. Adora is sat up in the bed beside her, leaning with her back against the wall, one of her hands idly stroking through Catra's hair as she fucks around on her phone. The overhead light is off, their desk lamp glowing in the corner of the room. It is still dark out, she can tell that even through the closed blinds.

Catra feels a yawn rising in her chest, splitting her face in two as she yawns widely and *startles* Adora beside her. Adora jolts, her hand jerking away. Catra finishes her yawn, blinking her eyes open to find Adora staring down at her in surprise. The last thing Catra remembers, she was in Adora's arms.

"What happened?" she asks, sitting up and blinking around the room. Adora frowns, dropping her phone into her lap to give Catra her undivided attention. That makes Catra purr, shuffling closer and drawing to a halt when she realizes the phone is in her way of curling up in Adora's lap. Normally Catra would just *move it*, but between what they just did and the fact that her hesitance is *obvious* and yet Adora does nothing to clear her lap, Catra doesn't have the confidence to crawl into Adora's embrace unprompted. She settles back on her haunches, ignoring the gnawing in her stomach.

"You thanked me and then passed out right after. I went to get us food while you were asleep. Yours is in the fridge," Adora explains, gesturing to the fridge with one hand and fiddling with her phone in

her lap with the other. Catra flushes, feeling her ears twitch, and nods. Right, that explains some things. The tension had been building so long - the desire so *much* with Adora all around her, even if Adora had to lay out how uninterested she was first - that passing out after kind of tracks.

Her stomach growls and Adora chuckles, shooting Catra an amused look before her gaze darts away quickly. With a reluctant grumble, Catra rises to cross over Adora and go get her food. Adora stops her with a hand on her shoulder, causing Catra to turn and blink at her in surprise. Adora immediately withdraws her hand, flushing and looking sheepish.

"Let me get it," she explains, already turning and getting out of the bed. Confused, Catra settles back down to sit cross-legged in her spot. She watches Adora pull one of the shitty cardboard boxes from the cafeteria out of the minifridge, tracking her movement through the room as she returns and deposits the box on the bed beside her. She barely pauses, already grabbing Catra's cup and turning back to the fridge.

Catra fights the urge to sigh as she sits up straight and grabs the box. She doesnt know what she was expecting. She was hoping Adora would at least make eye contact, throw her a longing look and maybe let her hands linger as she handed Catra the box directly, but that is her stupid lovesick heart talking. She is *trying* to kill it, but then Adora does shit like offering to help her *get off* and it rears its ugly head again.

Adora refills her water as Catra cracks the box open. Adora grabs her a fork from the cup of them they have sitting on top of their mini fridge, bringing it back over with her water and then frowning at Catra.

"No food on my side of the bed. You're *messy*," she tells her, making a shooing motion to get Catra to scoot over. Catra hisses at her and Adora responds by raising an eyebrow and holding the fork up in the air where Catra cant reach it. Catra glares at her and Adora meets

her eyes with determination. Well, she meets her eyes for a long moment before she blushes and looks away, but her expression doesn't soften.

Catra would point out Adora lets her *get off* on her side of the bed and yet is apparently drawing the line at *cafeteria fish*, but Adora can't even look her in the eye right now, so she keeps her mouth shut. Besides, she kind of gets it—Catra's sessions with her hand leave no traces, unlike the crumbs from eating. There shouldn't be any with fish, but Adora's eyes darting away has already sent a cold wave of worry through her. She doesn't want to argue.

She scoots to her side of the bed with a reluctant grumble and reaches out for her fork. Adora smiles now, handing it to her and then holding out the water she got for her. Yeah, Catra *definitely* needs that after everything. Adora settles on her own side of the bed while Catra alternates between eating and drinking. She asks for the time as she refuels, feeling significantly less groggy with food and water in her.

"Nearly midnight. I wasn't sure if I should wake you to eat or not. You finally seemed to feel okay," Adora tells, waving her hands vaguely as she talks and not really looking at Catra again. It is fair, perhaps. Adora probably can't make out her expression in the darkened room, so there really isn't a point, but Adora *usually* still fixes her eyes on wherever she thinks Catra's are.

She's in bed with you, you're fine, she argues with her brain. If Adora was really uncomfortable with what *she suggested* they do, she wouldn't be sitting a foot from her and turning her phone over rapidly in her hands. Catra frowns, sweeping her tail into Adora's lap and *waiting*. Adora lets out a soft sound and sets the phone aside, replacing it with twining Catra's tail between her fingers. Catra feels herself relax a little. Adora isn't being weird, *she* is, trying to look for signs of love she knows aren't going to be there. People don't have to look her in the eye twenty-four-seven, especially when it is too dark to even *see* her eyes.

“Are you feeling better?” Adora asks, her voice low . Catra watches her from the side of her eye as she finishes her food. Adora is looking down at Catra’s tail in her lap as she runs her fingers over it in a pattern Catra knows well by now. It is the one that calms her when her brain is running too fast. Catra could never reproduce it herself, but she knows it when she feels it.

Adora is likely worried about *her* then, and maybe feeling awkward considering what they just did. Catra did not intend to say Adora’ s name, but she did, *multiple times*. Adora was surrounding her and she is *weak*, so she caved. Adora took it as a cry for help rather than what it *was*, but it probably still ended up being more than she had bargained for. Catra takes a deep breath. She *is* feeling better, but she also needs to assure Adora - to convince her it was worth it.

“Yeah, I feel a lot better. Relaxed for the first time in probably two fucking days,” she tells Adora, because it is true. She is worried about the two of them, but her heat symptoms have subsided, and she feels better watching some of the tension leak away from Adora as she looks up and throws Catra a relieved smile.

“God. I was worried about just making things awkward for no reason. As long as it helped,” she says with a shrug before looking back to Catra’s tail. She is still doing the same pattern, but her fingers are slower in their movement, calmer. Catra swallows. *She* doesnt feel awkward, just hopeful and then idiotically *disappointed* despite how she should know better.

Adora feels awkward, though. Catra stands, turning away to throw out her food container and then grimacing a bit as she feels her clothes shift against her.

“I’m going to take a shower , and then probably go to bed. An hour nap isnt enough to do it for me right now ,” Catra tells Adora without looking back at her. She feels gross with her dried underwear clinging to her, and it will give Adora space. Fuck, she really hopes letting her lust drive her and agree to that hasnt put strain between them.

Adora breathes out an affirmative, sounding a bit relieved. *Space* was the right call, apparently. Catra takes her clothes with her into the bathroom, making sure the door to the next suite is locked before she turns the shower on. It is a specialized shower, meant to handle fur – hence how she and Adora got placed in this room, along with their two canidae suitemates – but Catra still isn't a fan of showers as a *concept*, regardless of concessions meant to make them easier.

It isn't helped that she is worried about her and Adora the whole time she washes. It turns out she has no need to be, because when she emerges from the shower, Adora has already turned the light off and gone to bed. She is splayed out on her side of the bed, a little off to the side, leaving space open on the right for Catra. Catra draws in a sharp breath and climbs in the bed happily, curling up in a ball at Adora's side despite her still-damp mane and fur.

Twenty minutes trying, and she still couldn't get them fully dry, but Adora drops an arm to curl around her back, so she doesn't seem bothered. It isn't like she doesn't go to sleep with wet hair sometimes too.

Catra breathes a bit easier at Adora's side.

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Catra was worried, but they do seem to be *okay* at least. Adora has her morning class first thing, and she stays out to go get them lunch, but when she makes her way back she is acting mostly normal. She asks Catra how she is doing, and the answer is shockingly *still good*. She hasn't even gotten off again and she still feels fine. She doesn't tell Adora those details, but Adora is clearly relieved that Catra is feeling better.

Adora does her homework at the desk while Catra does hers stretched out in their bed. Adora hums to herself softly, and it feels like a normal day. Adora is a bit distant, but that might just be Catra feeling needy after spending the last few days all over her. She is pretty sure she is in her own head about this – it is perfectly normal for Adora to work at the desk.

The rest of the day, the rest of her *heat* goes like that. Catra feels largely relaxed, even if by Monday evening she feels her libido coming back. It is kind of shocking how long it was gone, and she doesn't even need to get off again until Tuesday morning. Her senses calm down, and though she *feels* like Adora is a bit physically distant, she can't tell if she really is or Catra has just forgotten what normal is after being extra clingy the last few days.

On Wednesday, Adora asks her if she wants to join her for breakfast before her morning class, and Catra begrudgingly agrees. Heats are only supposed to last *up to* a week, and she should be fine now. She *is* fine now, but going out again means she has no more excuse to cling to Adora while they are in their dorm. She is going to go to her classes today and ruin that anyway though, so she might as well get breakfast with Adora.

Besides, Adora has been bringing her food for a *week* now. Catra is a brat, but she would just be an *asshole* to make Adora do it now after everything she has already done for her. She agrees, and then feels a spike of irrationality and grabs Adora's varsity jacket from her before she can pull it on.

Adora blinks dumbly at her as Catra pins her ears back and yanks it on, her tail lashing. She keeps her eyes averted as she does so, not wanting to see Adora's reaction. "It smells like you," she grinds out as she stalks over to her desk to gather her lanyard. When she turns back around, Adora is watching her with wide eyes still, but a small smirk is climbing up her face. Catra hisses at her and heads for the door.

I didnt say anything,"Adora points out, voice far too satisfied as she follows behind Catra. She doesnt *protest* though, and that's all Catra cares about as she hunches her shoulders into Adora's dumb jacket. Catra loves this jacket, mostly because *Adora* loves it, so she wears it all the time and it smells like her. The jacket itself isnt that interesting, but how clearly it is *Adora's* makes Catra covet it. It sends a clear message on the rare occasions she finds a way to get Adora to give it to her without asking.

Adora is not looking to date – she is far too busy between school, and football, and *work* – but Catra is feeling possessive after Sunday night. She doesnt want anyone else *looking* at Adora, and between the scentmarks Adora let her leave and the jacket Catra squares her shoulders beneath, Adora *appears* to be thoroughly claimed. It isnt true, but Adora seems largely oblivious to the general level of *taken* she appears to any hybrid she encounters.

Adora bounces a little as she walks by Cara's side to the cafeteria. Catra doesnt actually need the jackets as a defense against the outside world – her senses have calmed down - but she feels weirdly emotional, and Adora bought the excuse, so she doesnt particularly care. Adora isnt judging her for needing a stepping stone, so Catra will take it as a small silver-lining to this disaster of a week.

It is nice, actually, to be *out* again. Catra hasnt tried to leave the room since Friday, and she maybe was going a bit insane cooped up in there, but the idea of being out in public while she was feeling vulnerable – while people would treat her like *Dee* did – was even worse. She is grateful Adora was willing to stay with her all week.

Adora has to wolf down breakfast at an *Adora* speed in order to get to class on time, and then they part. Catra eats her food at *normal* speed, doing things like chewing and swallowing, and then wanders out to one of the hammocks on the quad to wait for her class to start. She has time, but she doesnt want to go back to the room again before Adora is going to be there. The place probably stinks of hormones, but she wasnt really picking it up when she was never *leaving* it.

Besides, it is nice to snuggle down into Adora's jackets while she lays out, protected from the chill in the spring air and still surrounded by Adora's scent.

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Catra really *is* fine, but by the time she makes her way back to their dorm she has come to the conclusion that her heat isn't her issue. Strangers aren't making her skin crawl any more than normal, and she enjoyed sending playful jabs back and forth with Glimmer in the one class they share this semester. Catra is still *off* though, and from how often she is tucking her nose down into her jacket collar, she has a suspicious why.

She can't believe she is going into *withdrawal*, but for the last week she has been in near-constant contact with Adora, and suddenly that is just *gone*. Adora has been pulling away ever since Saturday, which is completely *reasonable* given that Catra's heat is retreating, but she still misses her presence. She misses crawling into her lap, and rubbing against her shoulder as they lay side by side, and the way that by day two Adora was making sure to pet her whenever she passed.

It is all things Catra *always* wants, but she normally doesn't have. They are touchy – they always have been, outside of the time period when Shadow effectively banned them from contact by giving Catra lashes any time she caught them – but they were never to the level they have been for the last week, and Catra is missing it already.

It doesn't help that after class Adora has a shift, texting Catra that she is getting a ride with Bow over to SCRA, and then she has *practice*. Catra returns to their dorm after dinner, and wrinkles her nose upon entry. It *stinks* of desire and hormones. She opens the

window and takes a shower just because the baked-in scent makes her feel gross.

When she gets out, *maybe* she scent-rolls Adora's jacket, but it is rare she is alone with it and if it can smell like her when Adora wears it, then all the better. She sighs as she crawls into her own side of the bed and curls up with her phone. She has homework, but nothing due soon that she can do without a computer, and she doesnt feel like leaving to go to the school library this late. She hates that place. Dust everywhere. Half her computer assignments she does while sneezing.

She nuzzles into the sheets, and she is comforted with the scent of *home*, but it isnt quite the same. She has to at least *start* tonight on her own side of the bed. She ends up on Adora's frequently even *without* her heat, but given the space Adora has gradually been trying to add these last two days, Catra suspects she is a little done with the constant contact. She hasnt said anything, and she has accepted anything Catra initiates, but ever since Sunday night she has been pulling back from offering.

Catra feels her tail thud heavily against the mattress. She really cant tell if she is being *insane* about this, or something is actually going on.

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Catra is being insane about this. Adora greets her like she always does when she gets back from work and practice. She takes a shower and climbs into bed to show Catra the fading traces of her bruise from last week and how its faded state compares to the new one on her arm. She happily chatters about how good their defensive line is while practically *tugging* on Catra's tail, but even in

the middle of an excited rush she is careful not to hurt Catra as she plays with it.

It takes her twenty minutes to notice Catra is laying on her jacket. Catra kind of *forgot* she did that, seeking out a way to bring Adora's scent closer and also overwriting it with her own for when Adora took the jacket back.

"You know how hard it is you get your fur off of wool? I mean everything I own has fur on it *anyway*, but it's like Velcro on my jacket," Adora tells her, shoving her lightly until she rolls over and frees the jacket for Adora to take back. Adora gets up from the bed to carefully drape it in the closet. She hops back into the bed and peers down at her from her spot kneeling on her own mattress. "Did it help?" she asks. Catra blinks up at her, and resists the urge to crawl on top of her.

"Yeah. Im feeling a lot better, but you know sometimes I need a jacket to be comfortable *anyway*. Having it be yours helped," Catra tells her. Adora nods, her face set with determination. She is in a *mood*. At first her focus was still on practice, but now she has turned it on Catra, and as much as Catra has been wanting Adora all day, she also *is not prepared* to be under her scrutiny right now.

"How are you feeling?" Adora asks. Catra swallows. *Extremely seen*.

"Fine. Weirdly emotional, maybe," she admits, begrudgingly, shifting her gaze away from Adora and pinning her ears back at the admission. It is true, but she mostly says it in self-defense. *If I do anything weird tonight, please don't blame me*. Fuck does she want to crawl into Adora's lap. Adora pauses, considering that.

"Emotion imbalances can last for a few days leading up to and out of heats," she says, no doubt an exact fucking quote from one of her medical textbooks. Catra just nods, her cheek rubbing against the sheet as she does so. "If you want my jacket tomorrow, too, let me know. I dont care about you shedding on it *that* much. Unless you

continue feeling off through the weekend, it probably isn't anything to worry about," Adora tells her. Catra narrows her eyes at the wall.

"I'm not your patient, Adora," she reminds. Adora draws in a breath and Catra realizes how *grouchy* that sounded. She sighs. "You're trying to make me feel better," she acknowledges, the closest she can get to a *sorry* right now, but Adora has always been in-tune with her, despite her obliviousness, so she probably understands.

"Are you feeling up to making a game plan for your future heats right now? I feel like we should, but I also know you, and you are going to keep shoving it off until the next one is already here," Adora tells her. Catra's ears are pointed straight down. Adora is right, she does want to shove it off for later, and hopefully *never*. Catra growls lowly. Adora draws in a sharp breath, actually sounding *worried*, and it is enough for Catra to turn her head and look at Adora again. Adora immediately looks away, but Catra doesn't miss the guilt in her eyes before she does so. The guilt makes her pause and finally realize what this is *actually* about.

Catra turns back over, her back to Adora as she heaves a sigh. "What we did worked for me," she mutters. *Guilt* is not what she was expecting Adora to feel when they finally talked about this, but of course she does. She has probably been beating herself up thinking she is *just like Dee* or whatever. Behind her, Adora pauses. Catra knows she is sending a lot of *dismissal* signals right now, but the fact that she even acknowledged it should tell Adora she is leaving her an opening.

"Can I ask you questions? Just to make sure everything was okay and we are both on the same page?" Adora asks. They have not been on the same page *ever*, not when Catra was planning their wedding at age six and Adora was showing her cool rocks she had found, but Adora really has no idea about any of that. *Outside* of Catra's hopeless infatuation, they have always been in sync.

Catra just nods. Question and answer is easier, at least. She will likely have to volunteer less information, because Adora has no idea

how to ask the right questions. Behind her , she hears Adora shuffle a bit closer, though her mattress doesn't shift so Adora must stay on her side.

"Can I have your tail?" is Adora first question, which Catra wasn't *expecting*, but also is not surprising. Without a word, Catra sweeps her tail back. Adora takes it in her hands readily, running her fingers along it and humming softly for a moment, likely gathering her thoughts. She needs Catra's fur sometimes, or her tail to fidget with, just to focus and calm her . "Okay , the set up worked for you? Staying in the room, taking heat leave, all that?" Adora asks. A broad baseline question, but it also an easy-

"Yes," Catra agrees, shuffling back a little to be closer to Adora so she can have more of her tail if needed. Adora immediately takes the extra two inches it gives her to run her fingers more fully along its length.

"And staying in my bed helped?" Adora asks. She is gearing up towards the big question, but any second they can *delay* it Catra is fine with.

"Yeah. Your scent is - safe," Catra agrees. She has to fight to keep from thudding her tail. The tip twitches, but Adora just twines her fingers around it, so apparently that doesn't mess with the relief she gets from this.

"Are you okay with what we did Sunday night?" Adora finally asks, her voice low. She sounds trepidatious. Catra nods, not quite trusting her voice. Adora lets out a slow breath. "Okay . Did it *help*? Like beyond *I don't care* and into *this was actually useful* territory," Adora asks. Catra can't help but snort. She swallows, hoping her voice will stay even when she speaks.

"It helped. I was getting about ready to crawl out of my skin, and everything was pretty mild after that," Catra says, trying to thread the needle between assuring Adora and not *throwing herself* at her.

Behind her, Adora is silent for several long moments, still just petting along her tail.

"What do you want to do for your future heats?" Adora asks, her voice even. Catra thuds her tail once, wincing a little when she feels it *whap* against Adora's knuckles. Adora releases her tail immediately, but when Catra forces her tail still again, Adora takes it back into her hands after a moment's hesitation.

As much as she doesn't want to talk about this, she can't take this *dancing around it*. Catra growls lowly, flipping over to face Adora again. It traps her tail beneath her hip where it trails to Adora's hands, and Adora's eyes go a bit wide in panic, but Catra needs to just her her *say* it so she knows if she has fucked up as badly as she feels she has.

"*Talk*, Adora. I can't tell if you hated it, or just feel guilty, or are okay with it as long as *I* am, or *what*," Catra tells her. It is unfair of her – she knows that to some degree, how Adora feels about it depends on how Catra does, so she really should not make Adora be the one to lay it all out first, but she also already told Adora it was okay. Adora stares down at her for several long seconds as she thinks before she drops her gaze to Catra's tail.

"If it helped, I don't mind helping you like that on your future heats if you need it. I would never touch you, you have to know that, Catra. I wouldn't be comfortable with that, but I can hold you to take the edge off," Adora tells her. Catra stares at Adora's downcast eyes. She was not expecting that. She feels *conflicted*. She doesn't *want* to hear Adora talk about how much she doesn't want her, but Adora is still offering to do this for her again. Adora clears her throat as the silence stretches on.

"You're my friend, Catra. It would just kind of be like the arrangement you had with Scorpia. I would never start it, not now you know it's an option, and if you feel like you need it you could ask me for it. I don't mind, not unless *you* mind," Adora tells her. Catra takes a steadying breath, trying to shove down the conflicting *disappointment* and

small thrill in her heart. Of course Adora doesnt want it, of course she just *doesn't mind*, but she is also willing to give Catra this again if she wants it.

Catra always wants Adora.

"If it is not going to make things awkward between us – it *really* helped, Adora. As long as you're sure and this is not one of your self-sacrifice things," Catra tells her . Her voice is almost even. Adora blinks, listening to her words, and then she snorts and rolls her eyes, finally meeting Catra's eyes with an amused and relieved gaze.

"Yes, because it takes so much *sacrifice* to just hold you. I dont care, Catra. Ask me before things get that bad on your next heat, and hopefully they wont have to be so bad," Adora tells her . Catra nods, despite how she is starting to suspect it is not the week of her heat that will be the worst part, but the week *after* when she has to adjust to losing all the contact with Adora. Adora smiles at her, settling to sit properly on the mattress and not just kneel, apparently getting comfortable now.

"Is there anything else you want to talk about? Anything that did or didnt help?" she asks. Catra just shakes her head. She has a *lot* more she wants to talk about, but this conversation has solidified for her she can never say it.

Adora doesnt want her , doesnt even like touching her . Adora is so uninterested in her she can be detached and academic about this. Adora *doesn't love her back*. Catra knew it already, but it fucking stings still to have it thrown in her face this way by Adora trying to be the most understanding friend ever.

Catra forces herself to relax into the sheets, and prompts Adora with a question about the school's defense line. It sets Adora off again, distracts her, and Catra closes her eyes and just lets Adora's voice wash over her. She can be fine with this. She doesnt need Adora to love her back. She loves Adora, and Adora does *love* her, even if it is

not in the same way. Adora will stay with her, *always*, they both promised that young and have only reinforced it over the years.

One day Adora might actually fall in love —with someone else —but Catra is not going to torture herself now imagining that day. For now, she listens to her friend's voice and comforts herself that in nine months, she will be able to slip into her bed and into her arms again.

Chapter End Notes

> And onto the next!Ill be posting the next fic in the series, a one-shot follow-up set immediately after otos, on Sunday in North America. Tere are two more one-shots planned after that before the series will be complete.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!